

# CUSTOMER SERVICE STANDARD OPERATING PROCEDURE (SOP)

## How to Handle Customer General Inquiry SOP

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Department Responsible: Customer Service Operations

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# INTRODUCTION

*Describe the purpose of your customer service department - who your customers are and what their needs are.*

The primary purpose of the Customer Service Department is to perform all support functions in a repeatable and reliable way, transitioning from haphazard methods to a standardized "One Best Way" for every interaction. By codifying these procedures, we ensure consistency across all service channels and provide the stable baseline necessary for continuous improvement. This SOP is designed to optimize three critical areas of performance: efficiency by streamlining workflows and reducing waste; quality by delivering accurate results that meet customer requirements every time; and safety by minimizing financial and reputational risks to the organization and its clients.

Our customers primarily consist of [External Clients/Policyholders] who rely on our expertise for [Account Management/Technical Support/Conflict Resolution]. Their needs center on receiving swift and accurate resolutions through interactions that are simple, clear, and personal. We recognize that customers do not view interactions as single touchpoints but as end-to-end journeys; therefore, our mission is to make these journeys effortless and empathetic, providing peace of mind and strengthening the emotional connection between the customer and the company.

By following this standardized procedure, staff members contribute to an ownership culture where excellence is not an accident but a predictable and repeatable result.

## CUSTOMER SERVICE PROCEDURES

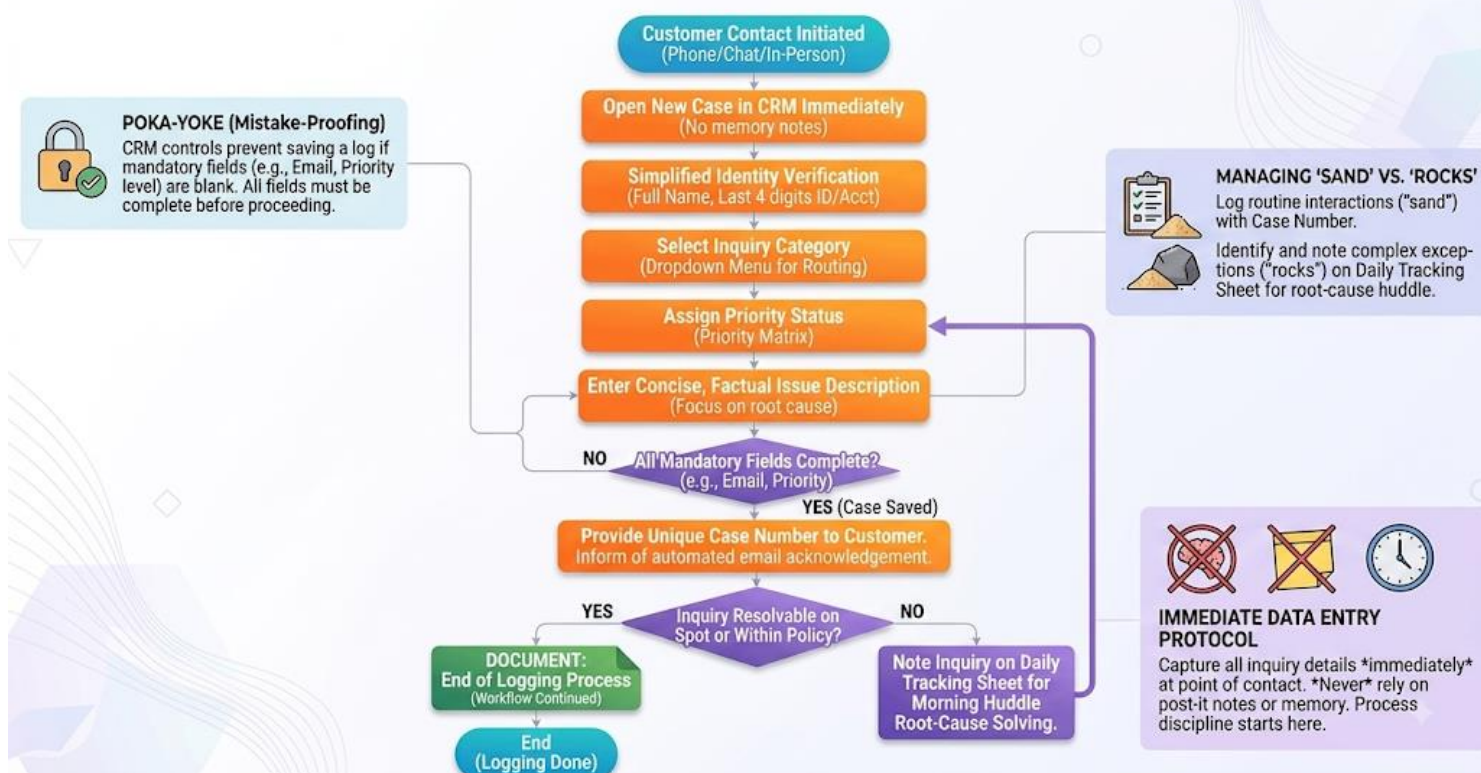
### User Responsibilities

*Describe what customers are expected to do to ensure their inquiries are resolved (e.g., provide accurate information, submit requests through approved channels, respond promptly to follow-ups).*

| Contact Channels (Phone, Email, Chat, In-Person, Web Form)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <p>Our organization provides multiple channels to ensure every interaction is <b>simple, clear, and personal</b>, recognizing that each touchpoint is part of a continuous <b>end-to-end customer journey</b>.</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li><b>Phone:</b> This is a primary channel for fielding direct consumer inquiries and providing real-time support. To maximize efficiency, we utilize an <b>Interactive Voice Response (IVR)</b> system for common self-service tasks, which significantly reduces agent-assisted call volume. Our staff is trained to focus on <b>“valuing the customer’s time”</b> rather than just minimizing handle times, ensuring that generalists can resolve most issues without passing the customer to multiple specialists.</li><li><b>Email:</b> This channel is essential for inquiries requiring detailed documentation and for providing customers with <b>written acknowledgments and case numbers</b>. We also utilize automated email systems to gather <b>client satisfaction feedback</b>, which serves as an early warning system for potential service gaps.</li><li><b>Live Chat:</b> This provides a <b>real-time digital support</b> option for customers navigating our website, allowing for swift resolution of FAQs and technical troubleshooting without the need for a phone call.</li><li><b>In-Person:</b> For face-to-face interactions at our branches or service centers, all staff—including security and support personnel—are trained in <b>emotional awareness</b> to ensure customers feel heard and appreciated. We prioritize flexibility for <b>truly urgent needs</b>, such as assisting a customer in a financial crisis even shortly after standard operating hours.</li><li><b>Web Forms:</b> Our website features standardized forms for the <b>reflexive intake</b> of claims, refunds, and applications. We strive to make this journey <b>effortless</b> by pre-filling forms with existing customer data and requiring only minimal, essential information for identity verification.</li><li><b>Social Media:</b> We monitor social platforms as a vital <b>“listening post”</b> to identify emerging issues and engage with customers in a more personal, informal setting. Feedback gathered here is treated as a <b>“gold nugget”</b> for continuous process improvement.</li></ul> |
| Inquiry Logging Method                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| <p>To ensure every interaction is tracked for quality assurance and efficient resolution, staff must log all inquiries at the point of contact using the following protocol:</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |

- **Immediate Record Creation:** As soon as a customer initiates contact (phone, chat, or in-person), open a new case record in the CRM system. Do not rely on "post-it notes" or memory; inquiries must be captured in the digital system immediately to maintain process discipline.
- **Identity Verification (Effortless Journey):** Follow the simplified verification protocol to value the customer's time. Request only the **minimum necessary information**, such as the customer's full name and the **last four digits** of their account number or ID, to verify their identity securely without unnecessary burden.
- **Categorization and Triage:** Select the appropriate inquiry category (e.g., Billing, Technical Support, Refund) from the standardized dropdown menu. This ensures the inquiry can be routed to the correct generalist or specialist according to the predefined **Customer Service Workflow**.
- **Priority Assignment:** Use the **Priority Matrix** to assign a status (Critical, High, Medium, or Normal) based on the severity of the issue and its impact on the customer.
- **Concise Documentation:** Enter a brief, factual description of the issue. Avoid wordiness or ambiguity; focus on the **root cause** of the customer's call to aid downstream agents who may handle the case.
- **Mistake-Proofing (Poka-Yoke):** The CRM system is designed with "Control Mechanisms" that prevent saving a log if mandatory fields—such as the contact's email address or the priority level—are left blank. Ensure all required fields are complete before proceeding.
- **Issue Tracking Number:** Once the log is saved, provide the customer with their unique **Case Number**. Inform them that they will receive an automated written acknowledgment via email containing this number for their records.
- **Exception Logging:** If an inquiry cannot be resolved on the spot or falls outside standard policy, it must be noted on the **daily tracking sheet** to be reviewed during the next **Morning Huddle** for root-cause problem solving.

## A Standardized Protocol for Customer Contact Logging



### Resolution Process

The resolution process transitions our team from **haphazard methods** to a standardized "**One Best Way**" for resolving issues, ensuring that every customer receives a consistent and high-quality experience. Every staff member is empowered to act as a problem-solver, treating obstacles as "**gold nuggets**" for continuous improvement.

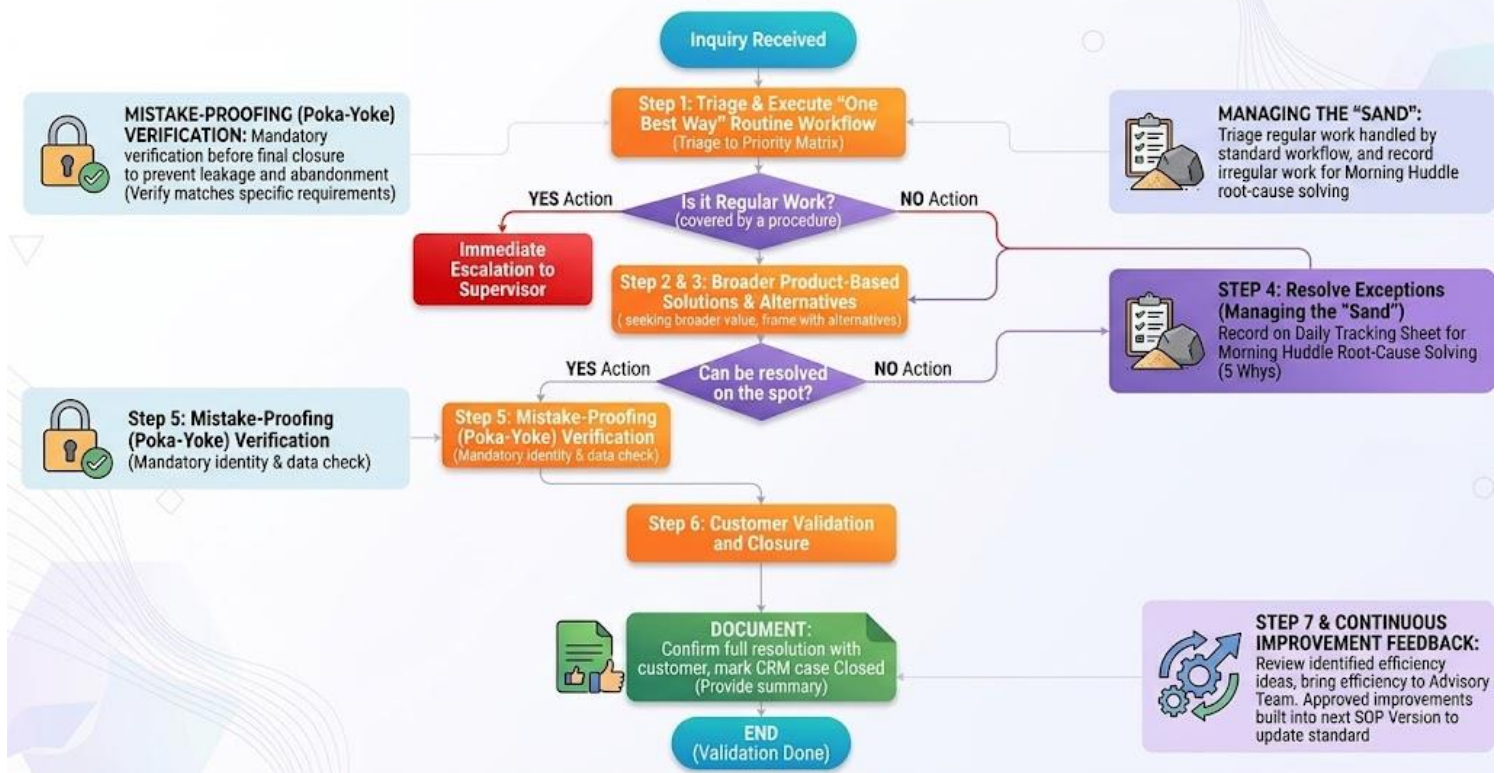
To ensure swift and accurate resolutions, staff must follow this standardized protocol:

- **Step 1: Triage and Prioritization:** Evaluate the inquiry against the **Priority Matrix**. Determine if the issue is a "regular" activity covered by a specific procedure or "irregular" work that requires immediate escalation to a supervisor or specialist.

- **Step 2: Execute the "One Best Way":** For routine inquiries, follow the **Customer Service Workflow Flowchart** step-by-step. Focus on making the interaction **simple, clear, and personal**, aiming for a "first-time right" resolution to eliminate the need for costly rework or follow-up calls.
- **Step 3: Provide Product-Based Solutions:** Rather than just answering the immediate question, seek to provide broader solutions that add value to the customer's **end-to-end journey**. If a direct "yes" is not possible due to policy, frame the conversation with alternatives so the customer feels heard and supported.
- **Step 4: Resolve Exceptions (Managing the "Sand"):** If an inquiry cannot be resolved on the spot, record it on the **daily tracking sheet**. These small, recurring issues (the "sand") must be brought to the **Morning Huddle** for **root-cause problem solving** using the **"5 Whys"** method.
- **Step 5: Mistake-Proofing (Poka-Yoke) Verification:** Before finalizing the resolution, perform a mandatory **identity and data check**. Ensure the solution matches the customer's specific requirements to prevent "leakage"—where customers abandon the process due to errors or delays.
- **Step 6: Customer Validation and Closure:** Confirm with the customer that their issue is fully resolved to their satisfaction before marking the case as **Closed** in the CRM. Provide a final summary of the actions taken for the customer's records.
- **Step 7: Continuous Improvement Feedback:** If a team member identifies a more efficient way to resolve a particular issue, they should bring this idea to the **Advisory Team**. Approved improvements will be built into the next **SOP Version (e.g., v1.1)** to update the organizational standard.

By following this rigorous process, we ensure that our customer service remains a **growth story**, delivering peace of mind through predictable and reliable performance.

## A Standardized "One Best Way": The Resolution Process Workflow



### Response And Resolution Time Frames

To ensure we are consistently "**valuing the customer's time**" rather than just focusing on internal handle times, our department adheres to a strict Service Level Agreement (SLA) that defines maximum response and resolution windows. Our goal is to provide a "**first-time right**" resolution to eliminate rework and prevent customers from needing to follow up.

The following time frames are categorized by the severity levels defined in our **Priority Matrix**:

| Priority Level | Acknowledgment (Response)                               | Target Resolution Time                                         |
|----------------|---------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|
| Critical       | <b>Within 30 minutes</b> (regardless of business hours) | <b>Immediate action</b> and mandatory escalation to a manager. |



|               |                       |                                                     |
|---------------|-----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|
| <b>High</b>   | Within 1 hour         | Resolved within the <b>same business day</b> .      |
| <b>Medium</b> | Within 1 hour         | Resolved within <b>2–3 business days</b> .          |
| <b>Normal</b> | Within 1 business day | Handled in the <b>normal course of operations</b> . |

## Resolution Tiers and Escalation

- **On-the-Spot Resolution:** Frontline employees in branches and call centers aim to provide immediate solutions for simple inquiries at the first point of contact.
- **Standard Resolution:** If an inquiry requires additional work or cross-functional coordination, it is referred to a resolution team with a promised response within **two days**.
- **Complex/Specialized Issues:** Inquiries involving complex legal, compliance, or specialized technical matters (e.g., mortgage settlements) may take up to **five days** to resolve fully.
- **IT System Escalation:** If a technical issue cannot be resolved by Level 1 support within **two hours**, it must be escalated to Level 2 with full documentation to prevent the customer from repeating their issue. Any ticket remaining open longer than **48 hours** triggers an automatic review by the IT Manager.

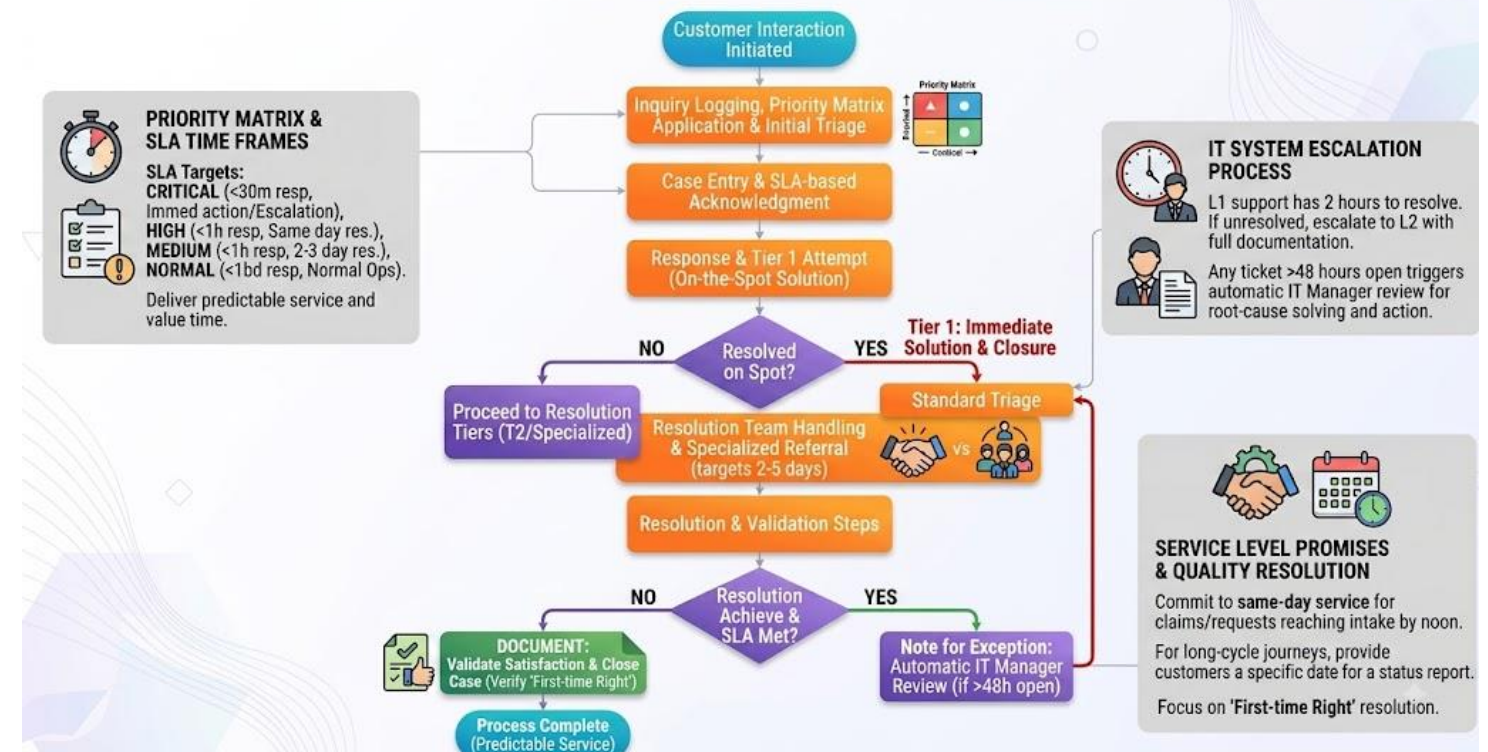
## Service-Level Promises

We are committed to specific operational deadlines to maintain customer trust:

- **Same-Day Service:** All standard claims or requests that reach the intake hub by **noon** are processed the same day.
- **Predictable Status Reports:** For longer-cycle journeys (like loan disbursements), agents must provide customers with a **specific date** for when to expect a status update via their preferred channel.

By adhering to these time frames, we transition from **haphazard turnaround times** to a predictable and reliable service culture that delivers **peace of mind** to our customers.

## A Standardized Customer Service Level Workflow: Delivering on SLAs



## Escalation Procedure

To ensure every customer issue is resolved with the appropriate level of expertise and authority, our department follows a structured **formula for escalation**. This transitions us from haphazard individual responses to a predictable

system where the most difficult problems—the **"sand"** that can disrupt the workflow—are identified and resolved through the correct management tiers.

## 1. When to Escalate

An agent must involve a supervisor or specialist if any of the following criteria are met:

- **Priority Level:** Any issue categorized as **"Critical"** in the Priority Matrix must be escalated immediately to a manager.
- **Technical Complexity:** If a technical issue cannot be resolved by Level 1 support within **two hours**, it must be escalated to Level 2 with full documentation.
- **Policy Exceptions:** Inquiries that fall outside standard operating policies or involve sensitive legal and compliance matters must be escalated.
- **Repeat Failures:** Any issue that has resurfaced despite previous resolution attempts (recurring "gold nuggets") requires escalation for **root-cause problem solving**.

## 2. Tiered Escalation Workflow

Our escalation process follows the organization's **Tiered Accountability** structure:

- **Tier 1 (Agent to Team Leader):** For simple policy questions or immediate roadblocks, agents consult their **Team Leader** during the morning huddle or through a real-time messaging platform.
- **Tier 2 (Team Leader to Group Leader):** If a problem is larger than a single team can handle, the Team Leader brings it to the **Group-Leader huddle board** for cross-functional support.
- **Tier 3 (Group Leader to Senior Management):** The most difficult or high-risk problems (financial, safety, or reputational) are escalated to the **Head of Operations** or **Senior Leadership** for final resolution.

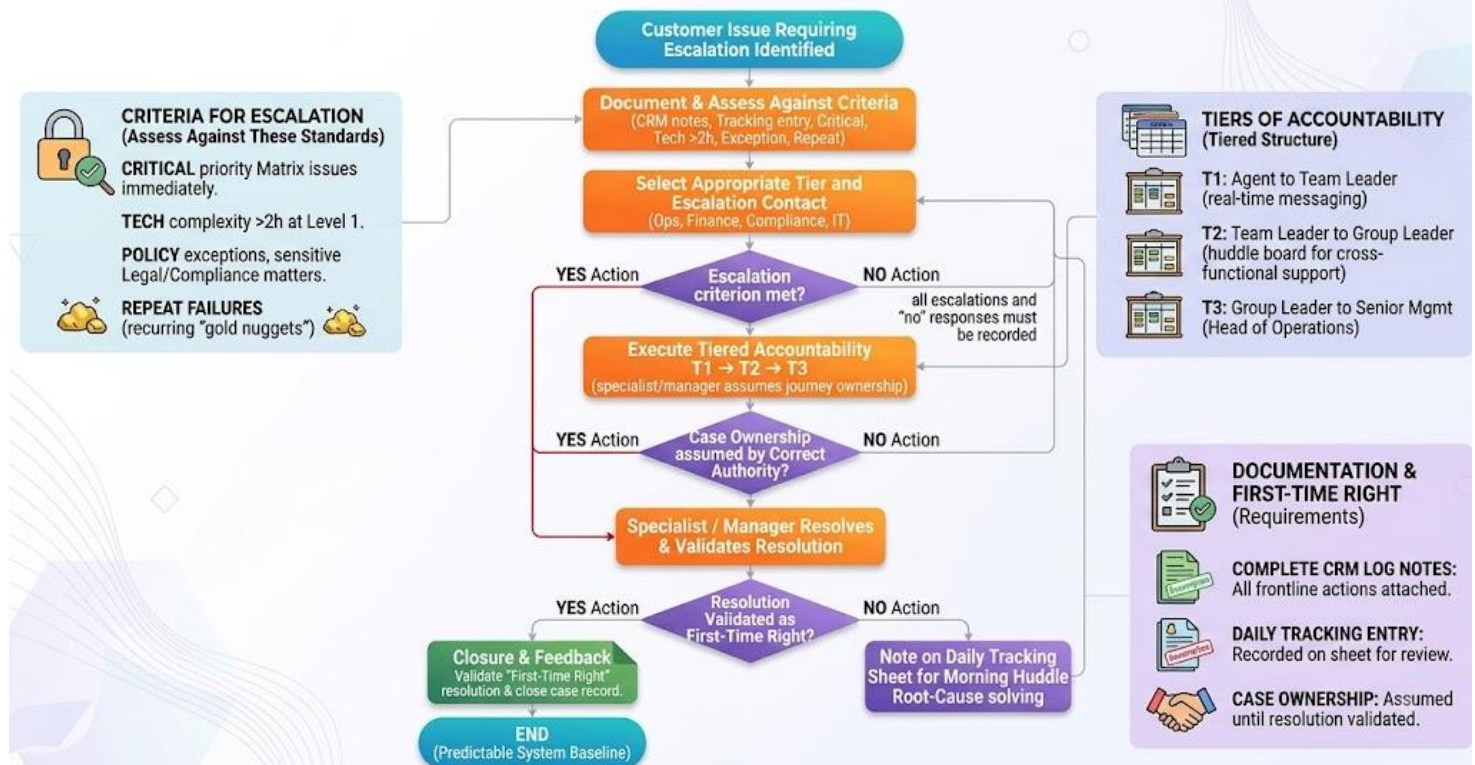
## 3. Documentation and "First-Time Right" Requirements

To prevent customers from repeating their issues—**"valuing the customer's time"**—every escalation must include:

- **Complete Log Notes:** Full details of every action taken by the frontline agent must be attached to the CRM case record.
- **Tracking Sheet Entry:** All escalations and "no" responses must be recorded on a **daily tracking sheet** to be reviewed during the next Morning Huddle.

- **Case Ownership:** The specialist or manager receiving the escalation assumes ownership of the journey until a "first-time right" resolution is validated with the customer.

## A Standardized Escalation Formula: Tiered Customer Issue Resolution



### 4. Escalation Contacts

- **Standard Operations:** Your assigned Area Team Leader.
- **Financial/Billing Disputes:** Finance Department Manager.
- **Legal/Compliance Concerns:** Senior Compliance Specialist.
- **System/IT Failures:** Level 2 IT Support Desk.

By following this procedure, we ensure that **human experience and expertise** are applied exactly where needed, while maintaining the stable baseline provided by our standard work.

## PRIORITY MATRIX

Customize this priority matrix to define your organization's prioritization and escalation procedure. This helps determine how to categorize and respond to customer issues.

|          |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|----------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Critical | Urgent customer issues that severely impact the customer relationship or business operations (e.g., major service failure, repeated unresolved complaint, safety concern). Must be addressed immediately and escalated to a manager. |
| High     | Significant customer issue affecting multiple customers or causing strong dissatisfaction (e.g., billing error, incorrect shipment, service disruption). It should be resolved within the same business day.                         |
| Medium   | Routine customer inquiries or complaints that impact service but do not stop business operations (e.g., general product issue, delayed response). Resolution expected within 2–3 business days.                                      |
| Normal   | General information requests or minor issues (e.g., FAQ-type questions, small adjustments). Handled in the normal course of operations.                                                                                              |

# ESCALATION

Describe your formula for escalating customer issues For example, define when an agent should involve a supervisor, and identify escalation contacts and procedures.

## 1. Criteria for Escalation (The "When")

An agent must involve a supervisor or specialist if any of the following triggers occur:

- **Severity Level:** Any issue categorized as **"Critical"** in the Priority Matrix (e.g., major service failure or safety concern) must be escalated immediately.
- **Time-Based Limits:** If an inquiry remains unresolved after **two hours** of active handling by a Level 1 agent, it must be escalated to Level 2 support.
- **Policy Exceptions:** Any situation where a frontline agent must say **"no"** to a customer or where an inquiry falls outside documented policy guidelines.
- **Risk Identifiers:** If at any time an agent suspects **fraud** or encounters high financial, reputational, or legal risks.

## 2. Tiered Escalation Workflow

Our process follows a **Tiered Accountability** structure to ensure problems flow to the people best able to solve them:

- **Tier 1 (Frontline to Team Leader):** For immediate roadblocks or policy clarifications. Team Leaders triage these during **Daily Huddles**.
- **Tier 2 (Team Leader to Group Leader):** If an issue requires cross-functional coordination or involves team-level capacity constraints, it is moved to the **Group-Leader huddle board**.
- **Tier 3 (Group Leader to Senior Leadership):** The most complex or high-stakes problems (e.g., budgetary issues or strategic alignment) are escalated to the **Head of Operations** or **Senior Management**.
- **Technical Path:** Technical system failures follow a specific path from **Level 1 Support** to **Level 2 Specialists** with a final review by the IT Manager for tickets open longer than 48 hours.

## 3. Documentation Requirements

To prevent the customer from needing to repeat their issue—**"valuing the customer's time"**—all escalations must include:

- **Full Log Notes:** A factual, description of all actions taken attached to the CRM record.
- **Escalation Log Entry:** Details must be recorded in the departmental **Escalation Log** for performance tracking and root-cause analysis.
- **Customer Notification:** The agent must inform the customer that their ticket has been escalated and provide an updated **estimated resolution time**.

## 4. Problem Solving and "Gold Nuggets"

Escalated issues that cannot be solved immediately are treated as **"gold nuggets"** for improvement. They are recorded on **daily tracking sheets** and brought to the next **Morning Huddle** to identify if the SOP itself needs a revision or a new "One Best Way". If the resolution requires long-term effort, it is added to a **Tactical Implementation Plan**.

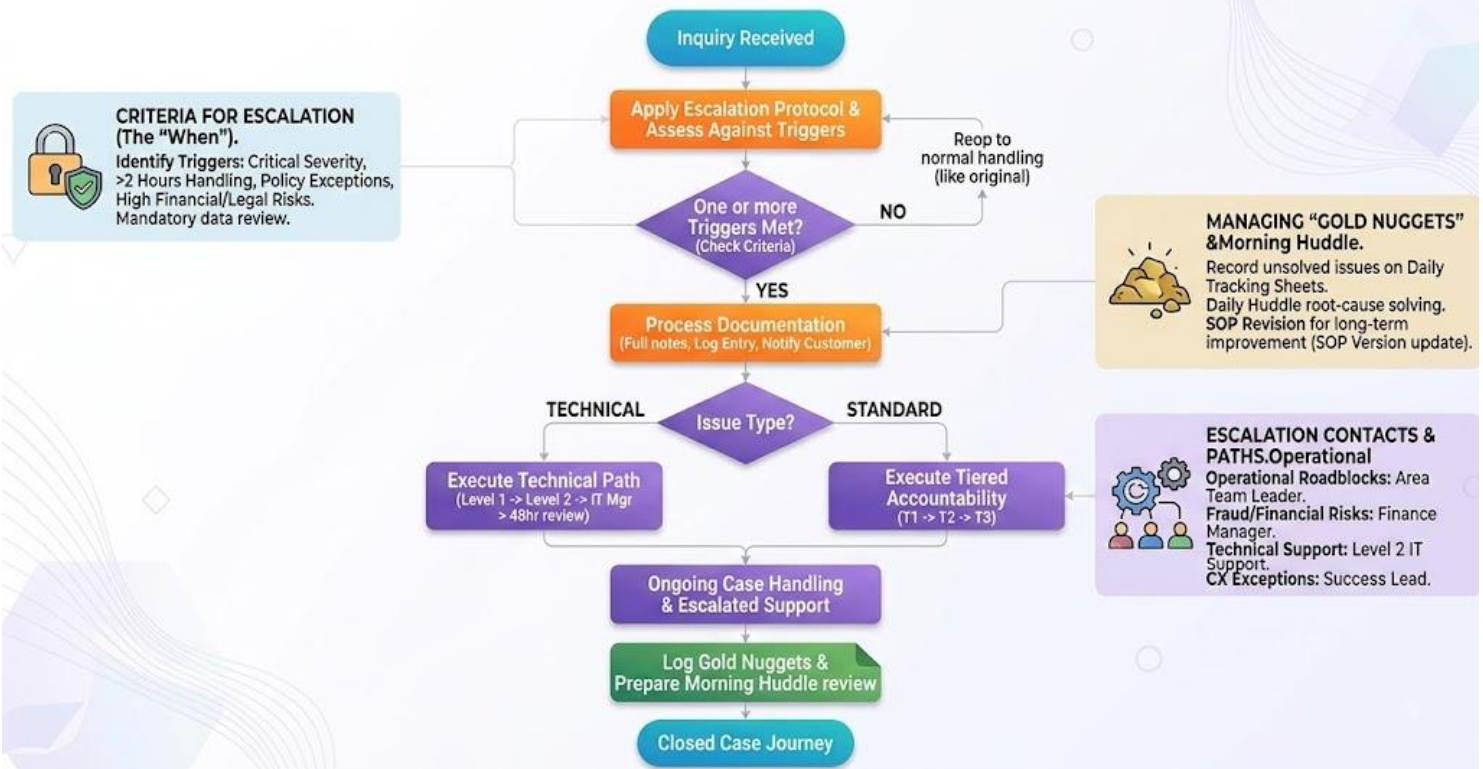
### Escalation Contacts

- **Operational Roadblocks:** Area Team Leader
- **Fraud/Financial Risks:** Finance Manager
- **Technical/IT Support:** Level 2 IT Support Desk



- **Customer Experience Exceptions:** Customer Success Lead

## A Standardized Escalation Workflow: Criteria & Tiered Accountability



## Examples

Provide sample case scenarios to illustrate how the SOP works.

The following sample case scenarios illustrate how the "One Best Way" is applied to different customer interactions. These examples demonstrate the transition from haphazard responses to a standardized, reliable workflow that values the customer's time.

### Scenario A: Routine Status Inquiry (Normal Priority)

- **Situation:** A customer calls to ask for the expected disbursement date of their processed claim.
- **Channel:** Phone.
- **Action Taken:**
  1. **Verification:** The agent uses the **simplified verification protocol** (Full name and last 4 digits of ID) to keep the journey effortless.
  2. **Logging:** The agent opens a CRM record immediately to make the inquiry "visible".
  3. **Triage:** Categorized as "**General Information**" and assigned "**Normal**" priority.
  4. **Resolution:** The agent consults the digital "One Best Way Guide" for status checks and provides the customer with a **specific date** for when the funds will be released.
- **Outcome:** The inquiry is resolved "first-time right" at the point of contact, preventing a follow-up call.

### Scenario B: Billing Error (High Priority)

- **Situation:** A customer sends an email stating they were charged twice for their monthly premium.
- **Channel:** Email.
- **Action Taken:**
  1. **Logging & Acknowledgment:** The automated system generates a **Case Number** and sends an acknowledgment within 1 hour.
  2. **Triage:** The agent categorizes this as "**Billing Error**" and assigns "**High**" priority.
  3. **Resolution:** The agent follows the billing reconciliation SOP, identifies the duplicate transaction, and initiates a refund.

4. **Validation:** The agent sends a personal email confirmation to the customer with the refund transaction number.

- **Outcome:** The issue is resolved within the **same business day**, meeting the High priority SLA.

#### Scenario C: Unauthorized Account Access (Critical Priority & Escalation)

- **Situation:** A customer reports through Live Chat that they cannot log in and suspect their account has been compromised.
- **Channel:** Live Chat.
- **Action Taken:**
  1. **Identification:** The agent recognizes this as a high-risk security/fraud concern.
  2. **Triage:** Assigned "**Critical**" priority.
  3. **Immediate Escalation:** Following the **Escalation Procedure**, the agent immediately alerts the **Area Team Leader** and the **Fraud Specialist**.
  4. **Ownership:** The Fraud Specialist assumes ownership of the journey, secures the account, and acknowledges the issue with the customer **within 30 minutes**.
  5. **Root-Cause Review:** The incident is recorded as a "**gold nugget**" to be discussed at the next **Morning Huddle** to determine if a Poka-Yoke (mistake-proofing) control is needed in the login process.
- **Outcome:** The risk is mitigated rapidly through tiered accountability, providing the customer with peace of mind.

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